By day, Galathea Bay, a crescent of sand in the wild frontier of Great Nicobar Island, is bathed in the shifting blues and emeralds of the Indian Ocean. Behind it rise dense tropical forests, alive with flora and fauna found nowhere else. Clear streams and waterfalls slice through the green, emptying themselves into mangrove-lined creeks where saltwater crocodiles bask in quiet estuaries. February is the dry season here, and the air hangs hot and humid. But, by night, the beach turns cool, dark and hushed, the moonlight casting a silver glow across the sea. From the waters emerges an immense shape, dragging itself ashore. She's a leatherback turtle, two metres long, weighing over 400 kg, one of the largest sea turtles on Earth.

In what can only be called a marvel of nature, she has swum over 6,000 km from the Australian coast, a solitary journey of more than six months back to the beach of her birth, guided by a magnetic imprint etched into her brain. Her flippers carve deep furrows as she finds the right patch of sand and lowers nearly a hundred eggs into a hidden chamber. It is a primeval ritual that has made Galathea Bay the largest nesting ground for giant leatherback turtles in Southeast Asia.

These giant creatures, as old as the dinosaurs, are only part of the extraordinary biodiversity on the Great Nicobar Island. On this UNESCO-listed protected biosphere, you will also find the Nicobar Megapode, a chicken-sized bird named so because of its unusually large feet. It builds

THE PORT OF AMBITION

The 'Holistic Development of Great Nicobar Island' project aims to transform the southernmost island of the Andaman and Nicobar archipelago into a strategic maritime hub



INTERNATIONAL CONTAINER TRANSHIPMENT TERMINAL

Eventual capacity

16 mn TEUs*



ECOTOURISM AND RESIDENTIAL TOWNSHIP

Estimated population

650,000

by 2050, including 260,000 workforce



POWER PLANT

Capacity

450 MVA

(Gas, diesel and solar based, to improve energy availability and sustainability)



GREENFIELD INTERNATIONAL AIRPORT

Peak-hour capacity

4,000

passengers



₹81,000 crore
Estimated cost of the Great Nicobar Island Project

**TEU or Twenty-foot Equivalent Unit represents the volume of a standard 20-ft-long cargo container*

166.1 sq. km
Total project area, 18 per cent of Great Nicobar's 921 sq. km



130.75 sq. km
Diverted forest land

35.35 sq. km
Revenue land

1.89 million
Estimated trees in the diverted forest land



711 thousand
Maximum number of trees to be felled

751.07 sq. km
Total tribal reserve area in Great Nicobar



84.1 sq. km
Project area falling in tribal reserve

Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY